Reimagining the Virtual School Head Title: A Comprehensive Analysis and Recommendation

Executive Summary

This report presents a comprehensive analysis of the current "Virtual School Head" title and recommends a change to **"Headteacher for Children's Social Care"**. This recommendation is based on extensive research, including analysis of survey responses from 135 professionals, document review, and evaluation of alternative options against key criteria.

The current title faces significant challenges: the term "Virtual" is widely misunderstood, the title requires frequent explanation, and it fails to reflect the expanded scope of the role. The recommended title addresses these issues while maintaining the valued "Headteacher" element, clearly connecting education leadership with social care, and positioning the role strategically for the future.

This report provides a detailed analysis of the issues with the current title, alternative options considered, evaluation methodology, and implementation recommendations to support this important change.

1. Introduction

1.1 Background and Context

The Virtual School Head (VSH) role was established to improve the educational outcomes of looked-after children. Over time, the role has evolved significantly: - Originally focused on looked-after children - Extended to include previously looked-after children - Further extended in 2021 to include children with a social worker - From September 2024, will include children in kinship care

As the role has expanded, concerns about the appropriateness of the title have grown. The title "Virtual School Head" is frequently misunderstood, requiring constant explanation and potentially undermining the authority and impact of the role.

1.2 Purpose of This Report

This report aims to: 1. Analyze the issues with the current "Virtual School Head" title 2. Identify and evaluate alternative title options 3. Recommend a new title that better reflects the nature and scope of the role 4. Provide implementation guidance for the title change

1.3 Methodology

This analysis is based on: - Survey responses from 135 professionals (73 from the first survey and 62 from the second) - Review of government documentation about the VSH role - Analysis of the "Reimagining the Role" document - Evaluation of alternative titles against seven key criteria

2. The Virtual School Head Role

2.1 Current Role and Responsibilities

The Virtual School Head is a statutory role required by the Children and Families Act 2014. VSHs are responsible for:

- Monitoring the educational progress of looked-after children, previously looked-after children, and children with a social worker as if they were in one school
- Providing strategic leadership to improve educational outcomes for these children
- Managing pupil premium and pupil premium plus funding
- Ensuring appropriate Personal Education Plans (PEPs) are in place
- Providing advice and guidance to schools, social workers, and carers
- Building links with other services to support children
- Championing the educational needs of vulnerable children

2.2 Evolution of the Role

The role has evolved significantly since its inception: - Initially established to focus on looked-after children - Extended to include previously looked-after children through the Children and Social Work Act 2017 - Further extended in June 2021 to include non-statutory responsibility for children with a social worker - From September 2024, will include children in kinship care

This evolution reflects a growing recognition of the importance of educational advocacy and support for vulnerable children beyond those in care.

2.3 Strategic Importance

The VSH role is strategically positioned at the intersection of education and social care systems. It provides a crucial bridge between these sectors, ensuring that educational needs are prioritized for children who might otherwise be at risk of poor educational outcomes.

3. Analysis of Current Title Issues

3.1 Survey Findings

Survey responses from 135 professionals revealed significant concerns about the current title:

- **Reflection of Role**: In the second survey, 42 out of 62 respondents (68%) indicated the title reflects their role "Not at all" or "Not not well"
- **Need for Explanation**: 72% of respondents reported they "very frequently" have to explain what "Virtual School Head" means
- **Importance of Change**: 43 out of 62 respondents (69%) rated changing the title as "Extremely important" or "Somewhat important"

3.2 Key Issues Identified

3.2.1 Misunderstanding of "Virtual"

The term "Virtual" is frequently misunderstood to mean an online or digital school: - 54% of respondents specifically criticized this term - Common misunderstandings include assumptions about online learning platforms - This confusion has likely worsened since the COVID-19 pandemic, which normalized virtual/online learning

3.2.2 Frequent Need for Explanation

Professionals report spending significant time explaining their title: - Explanations required across multiple stakeholder groups: schools, social workers, families, children, and colleagues - Time spent explaining the title detracts from time spent on actual responsibilities - Even within education and social care sectors, the title is not intuitively understood

3.2.3 Limited Reflection of Expanded Role

The current title does not reflect the broader scope of responsibilities that have evolved: - Does not indicate the inclusion of previously looked-after children - Does not reflect the

extension to children with social workers - Does not acknowledge the upcoming inclusion of children in kinship care

3.2.4 Lack of Clarity About Function

The title fails to communicate key aspects of the role: - Does not convey the strategic leadership aspect - Fails to express the educational focus and championing nature - Does not indicate the connection to social care

3.2.5 Perception and Status Issues

The ambiguity of the title may undermine the authority of the role: - When a role isn't well understood, it isn't well supported - The current title doesn't align with the senior leadership position it represents - May create barriers to effective collaboration with other professionals

3.3 Valued Elements of Current Title

Despite the issues, some aspects of the current title are valued:

- **"Head" or "Headteacher"**: 54% of respondents appreciated this element because it:
- Provides clarity and recognition in schools
- Conveys a sense of seniority and leadership
- Aligns with traditional education language
- **Established Recognition**: After years of use, the title has some recognition among those familiar with the education and care sectors.

4. Alternative Title Options

4.1 Categories of Alternative Titles

Based on survey responses and analysis, alternative titles fall into four main categories:

4.1.1 Strategic & Professional Titles

Emphasizing strategic leadership and professional aspects: - Director of Learning and Achievement for Children with a Social Worker - Strategic Education Lead for Vulnerable Children - Head of Educational Policy and Strategy for Care-Experienced Children - Executive Headteacher for Children with a Social Worker

4.1.2 Education & Care-Focused Titles

Emphasizing educational focus while acknowledging care: - Headteacher for Children's Social Care - Education Lead for Care-Experienced Children - Head of Education for Children in Care and with Social Workers - Head of Progress and Achievement for Children in Care

4.1.3 Values-Led Titles

Emphasizing values and mission: - Education Champion for Care-Experienced Children - Champion for Education and Life Chances - Belonging and Education Champion - Lead Professional for Championing Futures

4.1.4 Integration-Based Titles

Emphasizing the bridging role: - Head of Integrated Education Services for Children in Care - Education and Social Care Integration Lead - AD for Bridging Education and Social Care - Head of Belonging, Achievement & Assurance

4.2 Most Popular Alternatives from Survey Responses

From the survey responses, these titles received the most support: 1. Head of Education for [selected audience term] 2. Strategic Education Lead for [selected audience term] 3. Lead for Education & Wellbeing for [selected audience term] 4. Education Advocate for [selected audience term] 5. Director of Learning and Achievement for [selected audience term]

4.3 Headline Recommendation from "Reimagining the Role" Document

The "Reimagining the Role" document specifically recommended: **Headteacher for Children's Social Care**

This recommendation was based on the following strengths: - It keeps the trusted and respected "Headteacher" role - It shifts the focus from "virtual" to real-life strategic leadership - It positions the role as a bridge between education and social care - It is inclusive of all served populations without being clinical - It is simple, credible, and speaks to the heart of the role

5. Evaluation of Alternative Titles

5.1 Evaluation Criteria

Seven key criteria were used to evaluate each alternative title:

1. **Clarity**: How clearly does the title communicate the role's purpose and function?
2. **Accuracy**: How accurately does the title reflect the full scope of responsibilities?
3. **Inclusivity**: How inclusive is the title of all populations served?
4. **Authority**: How well does the title convey the seniority and leadership status?
5. **Stakeholder Recognition**: How easily would the title be recognized and understood?
6. **Longevity**: How likely is the title to remain relevant if the role continues to evolve?
7. **Simplicity**: How concise and straightforward is the title?

5.2 Top-Performing Options

Two titles emerged as particularly strong options:

5.2.1 Headteacher for Children's Social Care (29/35)

Criterion	Score (1-5)	Notes
Clarity	4	Clearly connects education leadership with social care
Accuracy	4	Reflects both educational and social care aspects
Inclusivity	4	Broadly covers all children involved with social care
Authority	5	Maintains the respected "Headteacher" title
Stakeholder Recognition	4	Easily understood by both education and social care sectors
Longevity	4	Should remain relevant even if specific populations change
Simplicity	4	Relatively concise and straightforward

Strengths: Maintains the valued "Headteacher" element while clearly connecting to social care. Simple yet comprehensive. Positions the role as a bridge between education and social care systems.

Limitations: Some might perceive it as too social care-focused rather than education-focused. May not explicitly convey the strategic nature of the role.

5.2.2 Head of Education for Care-Experienced Children (29/35)

Criterion	Score (1-5)	Notes
Clarity	5	Very clear focus on education for specific population
Accuracy	4	Accurately reflects educational focus
Inclusivity	4	"Care-experienced" is inclusive of various care backgrounds
Authority	4	"Head" conveys appropriate authority
Stakeholder Recognition	4	Easily understood across sectors
Longevity	4	Should remain relevant as long as care experience is central
Simplicity	4	Relatively concise

Strengths: Clear and specific. Maintains "Head" for authority. "Care-experienced" is an inclusive, person-centered term.

Limitations: May not fully capture the strategic or system-level aspects of the role. May not explicitly include children currently with social workers.

5.3 Other Notable Options

Other options that performed well in the evaluation include:

- **Strategic Education Lead for Vulnerable Children** (24/35): Strong on clarity and accuracy but weaker on authority and inclusivity.

- **Director of Learning and Achievement for Children with a Social Worker** (23/35): Strong on authority but lacks simplicity and may not include all served populations.
- **Education Champion for Care-Experienced Children** (23/35): Strong on clarity and inclusivity but weak on authority.

6. Recommended Title Change

6.1 Primary Recommendation

The recommended new title for the Virtual School Head role is:

Headteacher for Children's Social Care

6.2 Rationale for Recommendation

This recommendation is based on the following considerations:

6.2.1 Addresses Key Issues with Current Title

- **Eliminates "Virtual"**: Removes the most problematic term that causes confusion
- **Maintains Authority**: Preserves the valued "Headteacher" element
- **Clarifies Function**: Explicitly connects education leadership with social care
- **Reduces Need for Explanation**: More intuitive and self-explanatory

6.2.2 Strongest Performance in Evaluation

This title received the highest overall score (29/35), with particular strengths in: - Authority (5/5): Maintains the respected "Headteacher" title - Clarity (4/5): Clearly connects education leadership with social care - Accuracy (4/5): Reflects both educational and social care aspects - Inclusivity (4/5): Broadly covers all children involved with social care - Simplicity (4/5): Relatively concise and straightforward

6.2.3 Alignment with Stakeholder Preferences

- Aligns with the headline recommendation from the "Reimagining the Role" document
- Preserves the "Head/Headteacher" element that 54% of surveyed professionals valued
- Addresses the concerns about "Virtual" that 54% of respondents criticized
- Reflects the bridging role between education and social care

6.2.4 Strategic Positioning

- Positions the role at the intersection of education and social care systems
- Reflects the evolution of the role to include broader responsibilities
- Provides a foundation that should remain relevant even as specific populations served may change

6.2.5 Practical Implementation

- Simple enough to be easily adopted across communications and documentation
- Clear enough to require minimal explanation to stakeholders
- Familiar enough to maintain continuity with the current role while addressing its limitations

6.3 Alternative Consideration

"Head of Education for Care-Experienced Children" is recommended as a strong alternative if stakeholders prefer: - More emphasis on the educational aspect of the role - Person-centered language - Less explicit connection to social care systems

This title performed equally well in the evaluation (29/35) and would be a viable alternative.

7. Implementation Recommendations

7.1 Timing

The title change should be implemented strategically: - Align with the release of new statutory guidance as recommended in the "Reimagining the Role" document - Consider the academic year cycle for minimal disruption - Allow sufficient lead time for communication and documentation updates

7.2 Stakeholder Engagement

Continued engagement with stakeholders is essential: - Form a national working group of Virtual School Heads and key stakeholders - Ensure representation from the range of local areas and children served - Finalize the title with input from those doing the work - Develop a communication strategy for different stakeholder groups

7.3 Documentation Updates

A comprehensive approach to documentation updates should include: - Statutory guidance - Local authority documentation - Job descriptions and person specifications - Websites and online resources - Training materials - Communication templates

7.4 Transition Strategy

A thoughtful transition strategy should include: - A defined transition period where both titles are used - Clear messaging about why the change is occurring - Guidance for professionals on explaining the change to different audiences - Monitoring of implementation challenges and successes

8. Conclusion

The Virtual School Head role has evolved significantly since its inception, growing in scope and importance. However, the current title no longer adequately reflects the nature and breadth of the role, causing confusion and potentially undermining its impact.

Based on comprehensive research and evaluation, "Headteacher for Children's Social Care" emerges as the strongest alternative title. It addresses the key issues with the current title while maintaining valued elements and positioning the role strategically for the future.

This change represents more than a simple rebranding—it is an opportunity to clarify the purpose and importance of this vital role, enhancing understanding and support across education, social care, and the wider community.

9. References

1. Survey responses from "What Should it Be Called, Virtual School Heads?" (73 respondents)
2. Survey responses from "Reimagining the Virtual School Head Title" (62 respondents)
3. "Reimagining the Role: What Should the Virtual School Head Be Called?" by The Care Leaders
4. Government guidance on the Virtual School Head role extension to children with a social worker
5. Virtual school heads: section 31 grant determination letters
6. NCFE article on the role of the virtual school and the virtual school head

10. Appendices

Appendix A: Detailed Survey Results

A comprehensive analysis of the survey responses, including demographic information, key themes, and verbatim comments from respondents.

Appendix B: Alternative Titles Considered

A complete list of all alternative titles suggested through the surveys and workshops, with notes on their strengths and limitations.

Appendix C: Evaluation Methodology

Detailed explanation of the evaluation criteria, scoring methodology, and process used to assess alternative title options.

Appendix D: Implementation Timeline

Suggested timeline for implementing the title change, including key milestones, responsibilities, and success metrics.